



2026 BAY AREA EDITION

YOUR PATH STARTS NOW

2026 COLLEGE AND CAREER ACCESS GUIDE

23

CSU Campuses

10

UC Campuses

116

Community Colleges

A-G requirements current as of 2025–26 academic year.

Aid amounts reflect 2025–26 federal/state awards.

Always verify with your school counselor.

Know exactly what to do, when to do it, and why it matters from 9th grade to signing day.

9TH

FRESHMAN YEAR - BUILD YOUR FOUNDATION

YEAR GOALS:

LEARN A-G REQUIREMENTS

5-YEAR PLAN

JOIN EXTRACURRICULAR

SET GPA GOALS

EXPLORE CAREERS

FALL

→ Attend orientation, learn every campus resource
→ Meet counselor; map A-G requirements for 4 years
→ Join at least one club, sport, or activity
→ Create a study schedule and commit to it
→ Research career fields through mentors
→ Ask for help early if you're struggling in class

SPRING

→ Review grades — address D's or F's immediately
→ Research remaining A-G courses needed
→ Register for sophomore UC/CSU-track courses
→ Ask counselor about FREE Dual Enrollment at Community Colleges
→ Explore programs and internships
→ Reflect: what subjects excite you most

SUMMER

→ Participate in HGP summer immersion
→ Make up any failed courses before sophomore year
→ Read 2+ books to build college-level stamina
→ Volunteer or shadow a professional in your field
→ Start a portfolio documenting your interests + skills

✓ DO THIS

✓ Take care of your mental health, get support early
✓ Build genuine relationships with 2+ future rec writers
✓ Track your GPA every semester, small choices compound
✓ Use Khan Academy, BigFuture, College Board (all FREE)

✗ DON'T DO THIS

✗ Don't let grades slip, one bad semester hurts UC eligibility
✗ Don't skip extracurriculars, colleges want leadership
✗ Don't rely only on counselor, advocate for yourself
✗ Don't assume college isn't for you, explore everything

10TH

SOPHOMORE YEAR - EXPLORE & BUILD YOUR PROFILE

YEAR GOALS:

TAKE PSAT

START RESUME

RESEARCH COLLEGES

AP/HONORS

MAINTAIN GPA GOAL

FALL

→ Take PSAT in October
→ Begin building resume: activities, awards, honors, community
→ Explore career finders: MyMajors, CareerOneStop, Naviance
→ Investigate AP/IB or Dual Enrollment for junior year
→ Check if school offers CTE pathways in your interest areas

SPRING

→ Research majors that connect to your strengths
→ Review 5-year plan with counselor
→ Look into HBCU options alongside UC/CSU
→ Aim for A's and B's, your Jr GPA is critical
→ Connect with CCRS (College & Career → Readiness Specialist)
→ Sign up for junior-year classes: aim for 1+ AP or Honors

SUMMER

→ Stay active: internship, summer program, or paid work
→ Use summer school to get ahead or retake a D course
→ Visit at least one college campus (many offer free trips)
→ Begin a passion project, app, channel, creative work (final project for HGP)
→ Research scholarship databases: Fastweb, UNCF, Ron Brown

✓ DO THIS

✓ Aim for A's and B's, junior GPA matters most for admissions
✓ Start a scholarship tracking spreadsheet NOW in 10th grade
✓ Explore HBCUs, MSIs, and PWIs, know all your options
✓ Take on leadership roles in activities you're already in

✗ DON'T DO THIS

✗ Don't drop 9th grade activities, consistency is everything
✗ Don't ignore the PSAT, National Merit = scholarship money
✗ Don't wait until senior year to research financial aid
✗ Don't take only easy classes, strategic challenge matters